# Sunbeam

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Not Rated

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by limey_limey

Summary

Just over a month has passed since Adora hit Catra with her car and they started dating. Falling in love is easy, navigating that love can be hard.

Notes

Getting back into Hidden Kingdom is taking a bit more work than I thought, but it's underway have no fear.

This is just a little fun short with these kids that I enjoyed.

# Chapter 1

Grass trailed against her fingertips as she lazily swung too and fro from the branch of the towering tree that dominated this part of what Glimmer called a garden. It seemed more like a park to the scruffily dressed girl. Dangling upside down, Catra felt the blood rushing to her head and tried desperately not to sigh. It was great being Adora's girlfriend, the other girl was the best person she knew. It was so easy to be with her when it was just the two of them hanging at the mall, or the playground; hogging the swings and getting death stares from little kids. It was much harder when they were with the others.

Honestly, Adora's friends were fine. Once she'd started showing up more and more they'd taken her in like the stray that she was. It had only been a few weeks and mostly she just hung with Adora, but when they were all together they tried. It was just that Catra didn't want them to have to try to tolerate her. It didn't help that they were all so nerdy and earnest. Catra liked to get her work done and get out, not agonise over an essay for hours.

"Hey, Cat!" The loud shout came from far closer to her left than she would have expected, she berated herself for being so lost in her own thoughts.

Frosta was stomping towards her with that determined gait that she had, shoulders squared and fists clenched at her sides. The little girl was always so riled up, Catra had no idea what she could have to always be so mad about living in this garden of Eden, but here she was. Over the last few weeks she seemed to have taken a shine to the young hybrid, maybe because Catra wouldn't sit back and be insulted by the tween or maybe it was because she was the only one who would talk to the kid like a grown up and give her the unvarnished truth of things.

"Hey, 'sup kid?" Catra unhooked her feet and let herself flip to the ground, landing on her feet in front of the shorter girl who was looking at her like a bug under a microscope.

“Why are you over here? I thought you said that you were good at all the sports? Why don’t you go help the others practice?” Yeah, that was another thing that Catra didn’t enjoy about the group. They were all jocks, every last one of theme. Sure, Adora was a budding pro tennis player, but the others were just obsessed with being on their varsity teams. They didn’t even need the kudos or the scholarships that came with it. Something in the pit of her stomach always growled when she thought about all the opportunities the other kids in her group home didn’t get. It was one of the reasons she felt uncomfortable around the privileged group.

“They don’t need me over there, distracting them.” Truthfully she wanted to be curled up watching Adora but knew that the others wouldn’t let her be. It seemed like moving away hadn’t stopped that though.

“Come on cat-girl. Put your money where you mouth is!” Frosta’s brow was scrunched together as she held out a small wad of cash that she had pulled out of the pocket of her shorts. Catra could almost feel her eyes blowing out at the sight of what must be a hundred dollars being so casually waved around.

“What are you talking about, Icicle?” Her voice was grumpy, she was never sure if the kid was being deliberately cruel or just oblivious to their different stations in life. Thankfully at least the older teens never threw their money in her face.

“I’m just saying, I’ve heard all this talk about how athletic you are but all I’ve seen is a bit of gymnastics. I want to see you go over there and beat them all at things they’ve been training for.” There was a huffy edge to her voice and Catra felt as though the scales had fallen from her eyes. Somebody had obviously told the kid to get lost because she was too small and now she wanted the feline to show them up. Well, if it would earn her a fist full of dollars.

“Fine, shorty, I’ll go and make your sister and her friends look ridiculous,” she spoke as the two of them walked towards the large grassed area close to the outdoor swimming pool and her

eyes swept over the brightly dressed youths who were contorting their bodies in some very awkward looking stretches. “Well, more ridiculous.” She was gratified by the dark cackle that came from the shorter form at her side. Maybe she could get Frosta to be her sidekick?

“Hey! Losers!” Frosta’s sudden shout would have startled the feline had she not felt the girl take in a big breath just before. The others in the garden weren’t as lucky, and she watched as Perfuma overbalanced and toppled over in a heap of gangly limbs while Bow stubbed his toe and let out a squark. Sea Hawk, already far too close to the swimming pool while he preened, bare chested, for Mermista disappeared into the water with a splash.

Glimmer and Adora, who had been emerging from the house with a bowl of fruit and a jug of water, laughed at the state of their friends as they placed their goodies onto the large table that sat on the patio. Glimmer was too amused by the sight of Sea Hawk pulling himself out of the pool and trying to make it seem like he had meant to do it, to even scold at her little sister.

Adora’s attention was taken by Catra, hands on her knees and doubled over as she rustily cackled at the others. The blond was so happy that her girlfriend, she hadn’t asked the other girl if she’d call them that but the human girl thought it was safe to call her that in her mind, had decided to come back from the big tree and join them. It had taken all of Adora’s considerable self control not to follow her when she had slunk away when they all reached the garden, but she also needed to practice - even if the Moon’s didn’t have a real tennis court in the garden. There were still drills and stamina training that she could work on, and the ad-hoc court she and Sea Hawk had set up between two trees.

“What is it, you little monster?” Mermista’s voice came from the centre of the pool where she was floating lazily on her back, seemingly disinterested in what had befallen her friends.

“Catra wants to challenge you all to a contest!” They were all pretty sure that wasn’t strictly true, the prickly younger girl

couldn’t seem to get out of the way fast enough, but she looked pretty relaxed as the kid talked so they all decided to go along.

“Not Mermista.” Catra’s voice had its usual edge but the fact that she had used Mermista’s real name told Adora that she was serious.

“Why not? Thought you were a cat not a chicken.” Mermista’s sarcastic voice came from the edge of the pool this time, where she had folded her arms and was resting her chin.

“Can’t swim, fish face.” There was that steel that sometimes crept into her voice when the others were just teasing. Adora moved forward to wind her arm around the slim waist of the other girl and could feel the tension that was there.

“Another cat thing?” Bow asked with complete sincerity, but it made Catra bristle and shrug off Adora’s arm.

“A foster care thing.” She walked up to him and stood toe-to-toe, meaning to intimidate the older boy but he just gave her one of those oh-so-sympathetic smiles that he was good at and she felt her righteous anger deflate a little. Attempting to save some face, she affected the cocky demeanour she was so good at donning like armour. “Wanna race?”

Bow had been on the track team for years, he was fast enough to place more often than not but he wasn’t the best. He looked at the new girl, seeing that her ears and tail were quivering from where she stood so close. Whatever Frosta has said to her to get her to challenge them all, it was clear that it wasn’t something she wanted to do. He looked over her head and caught Glimmer’s eye where she was looking speculatively at the two of them and inclined his head towards her sister.

“Sure, Catra, we can do a lap of the garden!” Adora did a little cheer from beside them and Bow watched as she and Sea Hawk laid out a start/finish line of discarded hoodies. Catra even tore off her own and threw it down on the makeshift line.

Frosta dodged away from her older sister who she could see walking towards her purposefully, and set herself in front of the two would be racers. She faced them, raising her arms in the air as though she were about to start a drag race. Getting into the spirit of things, Perfuma joined Sea Hawk on a lawn chair beside the pool and they, along with Mermista began to whoop. Adora and Glimmer joined them and waited for Frosta to start the several hundred metre footrace. They watched as Bow lowered himself into his start position while Catra stood beside him looking bored and picking at her claws.

Then Frosta dropped her arms and screamed out 'Go!' with no preamble and Catra was a blur of motion before Bow had done more than push his body upwards. Every eye was trained on the feline as she surged forward, her body looking like it was made of liquid. Bow's own footfalls were eating up the ground, but as they watched him push and push himself to go faster and faster, he made no headway on the girl. Catra's pace was steady, each step exactly like the one before as she moved tirelessly, tail rigidly out behind her. Adora couldn't take her eyes off of the sight of such pure energy. She hoped that she wasn't drooling.

Bow slumped to his knees breathing heavily, a sheen of sweat over his face and neck as the race came to a stop where it had started. Never before had the distance felt so far or his legs so useless. He looked to his right and was met with the sight of a tail leisurely weaving back and forth. He looked up and saw that the younger girl wasn't even breathing hard, and instead seemed to have her multicoloured eyes fixed on Sea Hawk, a smirk blooming over her face. The previous disgruntlement seeming to have sloughed off of her as she ate up the ground with her nimble footed run. She must have felt him watching, turning to him and reaching a hand down to help him to his feet. He clutched the deceptively delicate hang and allowed himself to be helped.

"Man, you're fast!" It was, possibly, the biggest understatement that he had every uttered and he blushed as she raised an eyebrow at him appraisingly before breaking into a big smile that made him grin in return.

"If you think that's fast, you should see me on all fours!" She let out a little laugh at his stunned face, before dropping his hand and marching toward's Sea Hawk. "Hey, Moustache, want a game of tennis?"

Bow was left looking after her and trying to imagine how much faster it was possible for the girl to be. He didn't realise his jaw was hanging open until a small hand popped it closed. He looked down at Frosta who looked back at him smugly, as though she had won the race, before she trotted off after her new favourite plaything.

Shaking his head, Bow made his way over to slump onto the ground beside his girlfriend and rest his head on her shoulder as he, and the others, watched Catra take her new victim over to the make shift tennis court. It was less than perfect but something they had tried to knock up for Adora. The grass was short and the ground was fairly flat. A rope had been strung up between two low, sprawling apple trees and tennis rackets and balls sitting to the side. Adora had passed up on the set-up, preferring to practice her cardio and do stretches so it was good to see that it was going to get used. Bow straightened up as he saw Catra pick up a racket and head to one side. Sea Hawk hefted his own racket and spun it cockily in his hand, preening for Mermista who had her eyes firmly trained on his opponent.

"Adora, how much have you coached Catra?" The swimmer tried to sound bored, but there was something in her voice that showed she wasn't entirely comfortable with the idea that her pet jock would lose to a novice.

"We've messed around in my backyard a few times while I warmed up before practice." Adora was so dismissive, as though somebody being able to return balls to her after just messing around was nothing.

"He's going to get creamed!" Everybody jumped as Frosta's boisterous voice rang out from Glimmer's other side.

“Where the hell did you come from?” Glimmer spluttered out, eyeing her kid sister like some kind of ghost.

“I don’t want to be hit by a ball.” Frosta spoke like it was the most obvious thing in the world and they all found themselves nodding.

Perfuma, who had been very quiet while everything unfolded, moved over to the tween and handed her a glass of chilled lemonade and began to talk to her as they watched both the players do some practice swings with their rackets. It wasn’t long before Catra started to look bored and they heard her call out to the man opposite to serve or concede.

“Never! I fight for my fair Mermista!” The youth was in full ‘my honour mode’ then. Mermista groaned and hoisted herself out of the water, wrapping herself in a thick robe that was waiting for her, and hunkered down with Perfuma.

The first thwack of racket against ball echoed across the lawn and all eyes were glued on the action. Sea Hawk was a world away from Adora’s calibre of player, but he had good form and could hold his own in local tournaments and for the first ten minutes it seemed as though Catra was going to be forced to eat crow. That was until the furred girl locked on to his rhythm and began to move with a speed and grace on her side of the court to intercept the ball. Her returns were sloppy and aggressive, but she began to be able to return ball after ball until they are exchanging fairly respectable volleys.

The match lasted far longer than the watching teens had expected but eventually Catra’s greater stamina and lightening fast reflexes beat Sea Hawks technique and she was once again the winner. It was close though, far closer than her footrace with Bow. Both were breathing heavily as the tall boy walked towards his opponent and clapped her roughly on the shoulder in congratulations. He seemed to miss her flinch as he approached her and raised his hand, but Adora caught it and thought that she might need to talk to her friends about touching the skittish girl. As she watched, they both dropped their rackets and jogged over

to the larger group where Mermista gave her boyfriend a consolation peck on the cheek before getting up to fetch him a drink.

Adora grinned at her own girlfriend who looked abashedly back at her before turning her aloof grin back on the others. Adora joined Mermista in fetching a drink and was pleased when she took it over to Catra and it was taken gratefully before her retreating hand was grasped and held while Catra gulped down the water. Adora tried to hide the rush of pleasure she felt at this acknowledgement of their status.

"Here!" Frosta was in front of the two of them all of a sudden. It felt as though the child had learned to appear from thin air today. Adora noticed that she was holding something out towards Catra but before she could see what it was her girlfriend had grabbed it and thrust it deep into the pocket of her cargos.

"I haven't beaten everybody yet, squirt." Catra was obviously curious but had no intention of returning whatever she'd been given.

"Yeah, but you trounced the boys and I know you can do a backflip so you'll obviously beat Perfuma." That much they had all known already after routinely seeing Catra leap from trees.

"What about your sister?" Frosta always seemed to want to one up Glimmer, though Adora was pretty sure that it was mostly because she wanted her older sister to think she was cool.

"Well, duh, you're way stronger than she is so no way you couldn't throw a javelin further." Glimmer squawked off to the side in indignation.

"She is not stronger than me!" The pink haired girl was standing with her hands on her hips, bristling at the slight.

"No offence Glimmer, but I really am." There was no artifice in her voice now, just honesty.

“Prove it!” Glimmer was pouting and it was so cute that Bow was having to cover his smile with is hands.

Catra strode off to one of the apple trees and with one mighty swipe a limb as thick as her upper arm and about three feet long was in her hand. The eyes of all of the others were wide, realising that with just her claws she had managed to slice through several inches of wood. Mermista shivered a little realising how dangerous this new member of their group could really be.

Catra rejoined them quickly and passed the tree limb to Glimmer, smirking as the shorter girl almost dropped the limb that was heavier than she expected. She grasped it firmly in both her hands and began to attempt the make any impact on it. She spread her hands apart and tried to snap it. It didn’t even flex a little. Then she tried to use her knee but all she was left with was a bruise on her knee and a frustrated growl that she let out as her little sister started to point and laugh. Finally, vexed, she threw the branch onto the ground and pointed an accusing finger at the impassive cat-girl.

“That’s impossible!” She seemed to forget that Catra had already hewn it from the tree.

Catra barked our a derisive laugh before stooping to pick up the discarded challenge. “Anyone else want a try?”

It surprised no-one when Sea Hawk excitedly picked it and spent many minutes making himself go purple in the face. Everybody knew that the boy with the moustache liked to flex his muscles, he was always challenging all comers to arm wrestle after all, but even he had to concede defeat and handed the stick to Bow who gave it a perfunctory try before holding it out to Perfuma and Mermista, both of whom shook their heads, then it was Adora’s turn.

And of course Adora wanted a turn! She had beaten Sea Hawk at arm wrestling many times and spent years building her arm muscles with each ball that she hit back over the net. She gripped

the wood tightly and started to squeeze and twist, and though it flexed a little there was still no sign of anything like a break. Just as she was about to redouble her efforts, ignoring the pounding in her head as she strained too hard, a clawed and reached out and snatched it from her.

"Don't need you bursting a blood vessel, Blondie." Catra said it with affection and Adora's blush was covered by the red left in her face by her efforts.

"Alright. You think you're so strong, show us!" Frosta was almost on the verge of chanting 'Do it! Do it!'

Catra grinned a wide, sharp toothed grin, sheathed her claws and flexed her fingers over the bark of the wood. She tightened her grip and the muscles in her biceps and forearms bulged under her fur and Adora had to bite her lip not to gasp out loud and embarrass herself in front of her friends. She needn't have worried about them watching her though, as the sound of a crack filled the air. All eyes were on the short, lithe girl who was now holding twin pieces of wood, one in either hands and a shower of splinters falling to the grass at her bare feet. She stepped sideways and thrust the now broken branch into Glimmer's chest, whose hands came up reflexively to grab them.

"Sparkles, you gotta think more tiger and less house-cat." It was exasperating, really. Yes, she looked like a cat, but she wasn't one, and from the widening of the young heiress' eyes she was starting to see that the orphaned girl was more formidable than she seemed. Before there could be more talk about what she could do, or somebody asked her what Frosta had given her and she was forced to admit that she had taken money from the tyke.

"Ok, I'm gonna get out of here. Homework to do and all that." Adora knew that she could ask Catra to stay and do her homework with them, but she could tell that after that display the other girl felt exposed and needed to get away from the group.

The others all seemed dazed, absently waving goodbye as they gathered around to examine the tortured wood. Adora walked with Catra to gather up her hoodie and then shyly reached out for her hand as they walked from the garden. Making their way through the house, the two girls called out a goodbye to the Moon's who were working in their home office before making their way back onto the quiet street of the exclusive neighbourhood. Their arms swing between them as they walked quietly, occasionally bumping shoulders and shooting bashful smiles at each other.

Just as the guard office loomed ahead, Adora pulled Catra to the side, behind a cluster of ferns, dropping her hand and instead wrapping her arms around the shorter girls neck. Satisfyingly Catra reached up and put her own hands on her girlfriend's hips and looked up at her expectantly. Then they were kissing, slowly and delicately. Catra loved how Adora kissed her, like she was something special, to be savoured and not to rush. Catra wasn't so patient and her hands flexed over Adora's waist and pulled her closer. As things got more heated, Adora found herself pushed deeper into the little cluster of trees and just as she was sliding her hand down the collar of Catra's t-shirt, a deep cough made the two spring apart like they had been doused with cold water.

"Maybe save that for inside, right girls?" It was Huntara, a knowing look on her face as Adora's went pink and the little urchin she seemed to be dating looked down and worried the ground with her clawed foot. Huntara had reservations about this cat like creature that slunk around the private estate, but held her judgement for now. She knew what it was like to be judged on your appearance.

"Sorry Huntara." Adora's voice was small and the big purple woman gave her a smile and strode back to her booth.

The teens were left standing opposite each other, feeling uncomfortable for very different reasons. Adora because the woman she had a crush on for years had caught her kissing. Catra because she knew exactly what the brutish woman was thinking

as she appraised her and it made her bristle. Sky blue eyes met a mismatched pair and, just like that, the tension was broken and they were both giggling together.

"I really should go, Adora. You head back in with your friends. I'll see you at school Monday." She unwound her hoodie from around her waist and pulled it back over her head. Adora watched as the big, expressive ears popped out of the neck and reached out to help settle the always rumpled hair once the other girl was ready.

Adora wanted, more than anything, to invite the other girl to her house for Sunday dinner. It was a desire that burned in the pit of her stomach. She just wanted to see the other girl every day, but that was too much after only a hand full of weeks dating. Even still, she knew that if she asked the younger girl would think she was asking out of pity and reject the offer anyway. One day she hoped that Catra would be a fixture in her home, but not yet.

They parted a little way from the booth, sharing one last chaste peck on the lips before Catra, hands sunk deep into her pockets and touching the folded bill that say there, slouched her way down the street. Adora stood and watched until she turned the corner and was out of sight. She turned, blushing again when she saw Huntara giving her a soft smile, and made her way back to her friends.

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It was hard to find any time to be alone in the room that she shared with five other girls. There was always somebody coming or going. Clothes to be changed, makeup to be caked on or just homework to do in one of the quieter areas of the house. The only time you could hope to get the place to yourself was at mealtimes, but that would mean not eating. The group home was one of the better ones she had lived in, but it was far from perfect. If you weren't at the table at exactly mealtime, you wouldn't eat until the next meal. They didn't care about much, but they were sticklers for punctuality.

That night, after leaving Adora and her friends, Catra had made a slow walk home. She had eaten breakfast and had a good lunch of food that was far too extravagant for a bunch of teens at Glimmer's, so she knew she could manage without dinner. She had gone days without food before, missing one meal wouldn't hurt. She had things to do that she didn't need prying eyes staring at.

Waiting until she could hear the rambunctious sounds of dozens of kids eating dinner, the tinkle of crockery and the laughter of bawdy jokes, she sprang into motion. She easily pulled the chest of drawers away from the wall, careful to lift more than drag so that's she wouldn't make any loud noises. When it was far enough away, she reached out an arm, claws extended and popped out one of the floorboards. For anyone without claws it would be impossible to dislodge. She was always careful.

Contorting her body she reached into the small hole and pulled out a small metal tin, no bigger than her palm and about two fingers deep. Sitting up, back against the wall, she wasted no time in removing the think rubber band that surrounded it and popping the lid off, quickly surveying the small stack of notes that were inside. There were some ones and twenties nestled there. Even a fifty that she had gone for running an errand she was sure had been criminal but hadn't asked. She didn't count it, didn't need to, she held a mental tally in her mind. The pulled out the hundred that Frosta had given her and placed it beneath all the other bills to hide it, before pressing the lid back on, followed by the thick, tight rubber band that ensured it wouldn't accidentally fall open before putting it all back in the hole and closing the wooden board tightly into the gap.

By the time the other girls came up for bed, the dresser was back where it belonged and she was sprawled on her bed finishing homework that she had already completed at school the day before. They greeted her, friendly enough, none of them were what she would call her friends, they were all too different for that, but they weren't bullies either and that was good enough. One of them, a nervous lizard-kin, dropped a small package of

cheese and crackers onto her bed. It was an unexpected gesture and Catra muttered a thanks, making the orange skinned girl duck her head bashfully and slip off to her own bunk.

Catra thrust her books back into her bag and let it fall to the floor beside her top bunk. She rolled onto her back as she let the sounds of the others talking and giggling wash over her, putting her hands behind her head and looked up at the stark, white ceiling. It seemed like since Adora had entered her life with a bang, things were looking up for her.

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Hope and Mara stood, wrapped in each other, at the open French doors. From here they could just see the tennis court that dominated the end of their garden, and make out their daughter hitting balls back across the net from where they were being launched at her from a machine. Later, coach Netossa would arrive to put the girl through her paces. Practices were becoming more intense again as they headed towards a series tournament next month.

Mara tilted her head back to rest on Hope's shoulder where the other woman was wrapped around her from behind. She felt a soft kiss placed against her temple, even as her eyes stayed trained on the small, distant figure of her child. Sometimes she still felt guilty that out of such tragedy a blessing had been bestowed on her. When her friend's car had come off that bend and rolled to it's doom, so many years ago, she hadn't been sure that she would ever be happy again. When the will had been read, she had found herself bestowed with a vivacious tow headed two year old and felt more adrift than ever. She had been nowhere near ready to be a mother.

Along with the gift that was Adora, a presence in her life that had forced her to come out of the funk of losing her best friend, had come Hope. Hope had been Adora's social worker and as she worked with the orphaned little girl and the young, harried woman who had been so unexpectedly thrust into parenthood, the two

women had grown closer. Nothing had happened between them, Hope was the most scrupulous person Mara had ever met, no matter how annoying that had been in the early days. When Adora had turned four, Hope had handed her case over to a colleague and showed up at Mara's door with a bunch of flowers and a sheepish smile. That had been fourteen years ago, and she couldn't feel any regret even for a moment.

A whoop from the garden drew her attention back and she saw the resolute form of Netossa making her way across the lawn and towards Adora who was smiling and waving. The former tennis pro must have let herself in from the side gate, they'd told her she could have a key to the main house a million times but she refused good-naturedly. That Adora was just as in love with tennis at eighteen as she had been when she first picked a racket up in a sporting goods store when she was six, was a testament to the girls skill and dedication. Mara and Hope would love her even if she had no special talents and plodded her way through school. They told the girl that in every action, word and deed but sometimes the young blond didn't seem to believe that. It was a balancing act to encourage her without making her feel obligated to continue. Mara and Hope had long since agreed that the second tennis wasn't fun anymore their daughter could quit, no questions asked.

Mara wasn't sure that Adora would ever tell them if that was the case.

"You're thinking too hard," Hope's voice burred close to her ear as long willowy arms held her tighter.

"Nothing bad, just about what a lovely girl we've raised." She broke away from the embrace and turned to look into dark eyes that were shining with just as much love and pride as she were sure her's were.

"She is, isn't she?" Hope was a woman who could come across as taciturn and cold to some, but when you knew her she was one of the warmest people Mara had ever met.

“What do you think about her asking Catra if she would like to come to the tournament with us?” The orphan girl had become, not a fixture per se, but a familiar presence around the house over the last month, since the accident.

Adora had excitedly asked them a few nights before, if Catra could come on the two-week trip with them. They had agreed to think about it and their daughter had seemed satisfied by that. They had yet to make a decision.

“I think that Catra would need to be asked delicately, or she’s going to think its charity. She’s a very proud young woman.” Hope had known Catra for almost as long as she had been a part of Adora’s life, although in a very different capacity, and had a greater understanding of her.

“I think it would be a good idea, get Adora to smell the roses and not just focus on the matches when she isn’t on the court.” She often found herself worried at Adora’s single mindedness.

Hope reached out and cupped her jaw gently, “we can sit down and talk about this with her tonight then.”

A happy shout from the garden called their attention back and they saw Adora beaming and waving for them to come out. Who were they to say no? Hand in hand they ambled down to the practice court.

# Chapter 2

She had found the absolute premium spot in the dappled shade of the broad old oak tree. It let in just enough sunlight to keep her warm, leaving patterns of gold across her torso and legs, while her face was shadowed. Her eyes were closed second after she let her body flop down into the soft grass. The nap that was clawing her down into an abyss took a little longer to take hold, her ears catching the shouting and laughter of the other teens who were running around the bottom of the little incline she had put herself on.

Her body screamed at her to just let go, days of barely any sleep taking their toll on the girl, and finally hearing that Scorpia was laughing along with her new friends, the last tension in her body ebbed away and she groped out to sloppily grab her balled up sweatshirt and stuff it under her head before finally drifting off. She hadn't been sure if she should let the older girl tag along with her, whether Adora's wealthy friends would think it was weird that her best friend was a twenty-two year old scorpioni, but eventually she had let both her fair haired girlfriend and her friend convince her it was a good idea. The moment the teens had met the college student it was obvious that they were going to hit it off, Scorpia was hard not to like, no matter how hard you tried. That had been her last worry for the day solved, so once her sociability metre had run down to zero she had found her way to this quiet spot.

It was rare that she felt safe, certainly not usually out in the open, no matter how many times she had slept on a bench or on a roof but knowing that she had actual people who cared about her nearby seemed to ease her worries. Her body curled into a little ball on her side, fist balled under her chin and drifted off, one ear still cocked for danger.

The group home was one of the better ones that she had lived in, nobody really cared where she was and what she was doing but there was food on the table and no-one shouting at her so it was

a win. The rooms were clean and there was always warm water to shower. She even only had to share her room with four five other girls which was a step up from the big dormitory of her last place where there had been twenty girls in a long, draughty room. Except, it still meant sleeping in the same room as other people. Human people. They snorted and snored, which after a lifetime spent sharing a room she could tune out, but at this time of year there was the added delight of nighttime coughs and wheezes which made it almost impossible for the hybrid to sleep no matter how exhausted she was when she lay down.

Soon the area under the tree was full of soft purrs.

Adora realised quickly that her girlfriend was no longer among the rest of the group who were hanging around the picnic blanket and talking animatedly. She had been excited that Catra had invited her friend Scorpia to join them at the park. The younger girl was slow to open up, but the pair spent so much time together in the library and in her kitchen that Adora felt like she had known her all her life. It was more awkward when they were with her friends.

Adora loved her group of friends, it had taken her a while to get used to them all but now it was hard to imagine them not being in her life. Scorpia was just as loud and outgoing as her own friends, which had surprised the tennis player. She had expected Catra's best friend (though the younger girl never her gave that title to the big woman it was obvious how important she was to her) to be some black clad and morose figure who would huff and glower. Instead the scopioni embodiment of sunshine had walked into the park and instantly started to make fiends. Adora found her a little too loud but Perfuma and Bow seemed taken with her.

Seeing that Scorpia was off with Perfuma and Bow, looking at some weird looking flowers and talking animatedly, she took the opportunity to leave the others lounging on the picnic blanket and head up the small hill in search of her girl. It wasn't hard to spot the slumbering form nestled under the tree. Nobody else was up here in the shade, people preferring to make the most of the unseasonably warm day and the last of the warm sun.

As quietly as she could, Adora made her way over to the tree and lowered herself down against the trunk, her legs pulled up to her chest as she folded her body to fit between the sleeping girl and the trunk. Carefully, she switched out the bundle under Catra's head for her own thighs and was relieved that rather than waking and telling her to go away, a yellow eye blinked up at her before closing again as the shaggy head nestled more comfortably onto her lap and a hand tucked itself beneath.

Long fingers reached out and began to gently run through the short hair that was already starting to grow out. Vibrating purrs rumbled through her fingers and her leg and she was content. Her eyes strayed to the distance and she watched the toy-like figures of her friends starting to play a boisterous game of tag that they were all really too old for. It made the smile already on her face grow as the fingers of her free hand began to pluck tiny daisies from around her and stuck them into Catra's thick mane.

They sat there quietly, basking in each others company. Adora began to gently hum, her mind peaceful in a way that it seldom was. Her mothers told her not to worry, that wherever she placed in a tournament they would be proud, however she did on a test they would support her. But it was hard to believe that, her own demons (and Madam Weaver's voice) were always loud inside her mind. She always felt like she had to be the best. She didn't feel that way around Catra. It was like she could just switch off around her.

The human girl had started to doze herself, head lulling to the side as the light through the leaves dappled across her closed eyelids. That was the vision that graced Catra when she turned onto her back and opened her eyes. She knew Adora was there, her self preservation had made sure she checked who was touching her, but she had surprised herself by being able to go back to sleep. Now, looking up in the shaded light cast by the tree, she examined the other girl as she would a piece of art.

Golden flecks of sunlight danced across her face, the sunbeams seeming to kiss at her eyelids and making the girl look like an

angel. The feeling in Catra's chest swelled, almost feeling too big to be contained and the gentle tingle of affection that had been languidly spreading through her limbs seemed to seize and constrict her body. Panic began to edge its way into her. She could not start to rely on anyone to take care of her or make her happy. Any time she ever had it had been taken away by harsh words and cruel actions. Adora liked her now, sure, but once she was off on the tennis circuit full time and meeting all kinds of celebrities and athletes her dalliance with the creature from the other side of the tracks would be nothing but a distant memory that she might share at a cocktail party to show how down to earth she was.

Fists clenching at her sides as the scenarios she had made in her head started to eat away at her as her tail began an agitated thrashing, she sat up carefully from the still dozing girl and looked around for her top and bag that had been displaced. She could just head off, get some space, maybe skip school for a couple of days until she didn't feel so much. Just as she was about to walk away, a sleepy voice drifted up to her.

"Whatcha' doin'?" And like that she couldn't walk away. Her shoulders slumped and she sank back to the grass, opposite the slowly waking girl now.

"Nothing. Just stretching." She felt bad for lying to the sweet girl, which in turn made her feel more conflicted emotions.

Adora reached across the small distance between them and took the fidgeting hands of the smaller girl. She loved when they held hands, the feel of the long fingers wrapped in hers, the softness of her palm and the feel of fur brushing against her. She knew she was smiling dopily at the cat-girl but she didn't care. She was happy. She didn't notice the skittish look on the other girls face.

"Oh, I've been meaning to tell you! My mums said you could come with us during the tournament!" She tried to make it sound cool, kind of throw away. She didn't want to sound too excited or too desperate for the other girl to come. Even though she was

possibly more excited than she had ever been to ask anyone anything.

Catra's ears began to ring with the sound of her blood boiling. Had Adora really just told her what she was going to be doing? Of course she was. Why ask the homeless kid if she wanted to do something, she would feel grateful for any chance to do something she couldn't afford, wouldn't she? A growl boiled up from deep in her chest as she tore her hands from he startled looking blond's and leapt to her feet, grabbing her things from the floor and starting to walk away.

Adora was dazed, the sound that had just come out of the other girl had been frightening and nothing like what she had heard before. It took her a moment to realise that the younger girl was walking away, but when she did she scrambled to her own feet and followed quickly off of her and reached out to retake one of her hands. She was hurt when the hand was jerked away and she noted the claws begin to come out, literally.

"Catra, what's wrong?" Her voice was soft, as though she was talking to a small child or wild animal. It was exactly the wrong thing to do.

"What's wrong? I don't need your pity or your charity, Adora. You tell me what I'm going to do, you don't ask me? I'm not so desperate for scraps from your table that I'll just follow you round like a fucking puppy." Catra was seething, working herself up and not really thinking about what the other girl had really said. Years of being teased and pushed around, or people making her decisions for her seemed to be spilling out and she couldn't stop the torrent that was aimed at the wide eyes blond.

"Ca…" Adora had tears in her eyes as she tried to figure out what she had done wrong.

"Go back to your friends, Adora. Tell Scorpia I'll make my own way home." Without another word the feline was running down

the hill and away, leaving Adora with tears running down her face and nothing but confusion in her heart.

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Hiding was sometimes harder than running. Finding a spot to be still and quiet when you could hear everything within two hundred feet was tough. At least when you ran you could lose yourself in the sounds of your own heart and breathing. But you couldn't run forever. She should know. Catra had tried to run ever since she was a kitten but she could never outrun her life. Sprinting away from Adora and her friends, glad of her feline speed and grace had seemed like a good idea at the time.

Now, sitting on the roof of the mall as the clouds gathered overhead, she shivered and pulled her hood over her ears to block out the wind. The day that had started full of sunshine and happiness, had turned stormy. She could smell the rain in the air and knew that it was only a matter of time before she was soaked to the skin. Thankfully the mall was still open, though as she pulled the door open and snuck her way back to the food court, she could see that most of the shutters were down and her stomach growled. She couldn't even swipe a snack, and her pockets were empty anyway. Walking out into the night, she ran quickly back to the group home, narrowly avoiding the deluge that was to fill the night.

Sneaking in through the window of her room, thankfully left open tonight, she was greeted by the welcome darkness that told her that all of the others were asleep. Her vision was almost as sharp in the night as the day, meant that it was easy enough to get up to her bunk and grab her pillow and comforter. She jumped back down lightly, not wanting to disturb the others, and crept her way to the disused bathroom at the end of the hall. The sink was cracked in half and the toilet didn't flush, but at least there was a bathtub in there. Catra ignored the keep out sign on the door and let herself in, locking the door behind her before piling her comforter and pillow into the bath and climbing in. The room was colder than the rest of the house, the enamel of the bath cold

underneath her but at least it was quiet save for the sound of the rain now beating against the class of the window.

Still dressed in her hoodie and pants, she curled onto a small ball and tried not to think about laying in the same position that morning, gentle hands running through her hair. She knew she's hurt Adora with her words and by running away. There was no way that the other girl would want to talk to her now. She had only been trying to be kind and instead Catra had bitten her head off and embarrassed her in front of her friends. It had been nice while it lasted, more than nice. Wonderful. But she had known from the start that the other girl was too good for her, it had only been a matter of time before she realised it too. Seemed like two months was what it took.

Trying to zone out into the sound of the raindrops, body screaming for rest, she squeezed her eyes shut and hoped that morning would come quickly.

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Knowing that she could only skip out on school for so long before Miss Hope and the group home got a call, Catra bowed her head and shouldered her way down the hallway. She was almost vibrating with anxiety and it didn't take long for the early arrivers to move out of the way as she made her way to the library. If she was lucky, she could get to her homeroom before Adora and her friends even got inside the building. She had tried to tell herself that the human girl wouldn't care where she had gone, but she knew that wasn't true. After the initial rush of indignation and its accompanying rage in the park, Catra had quickly realised that she had overreacted but the proud youth couldn't bring herself to apologise.

Since the park, Catra had managed to dodge Scorpia. It was easy enough without a cell phone not to get messages that were left on the answerphone that the kids at the home had access to. The big scorpioni was bound to show up on the doorstep soon if she

didn’t talk to her, she was like a dog with a bone. It was how she had managed to befriend an angry, lonely kid in the first place.

Just as she was about to step into the library a hand landed on her shoulder and she had to bite her lip not to yelp or lash out. She had long since learned that her in born urge to fight when confronted just led to punishment, and in this school would almost certainly lead to police. She allowed herself to be turned to face the person who had accosted her, feeling the heavy wooden door softly close against her back, blocking her from any kind of escape.

The hand tightened its grip, long boney fingers digging into the tender skin where her shoulder met her neck. Catra kicked herself for not knowing that this woman was coming up behind her. The smell of her perfume enveloped the girl now, it was dark and rich, always catching at the back of her throat. Usually it wafted down the hallways and offered the feline a chance to dodge the headmistress before she appeared. Today she had been too wrapped up in her own morose thoughts that she had missed the ambush and now it looked like she was about to face the music after all. The murderous gleam in the tall woman’s eye and the twisted, self satisfied smirk on the scarred face told Catra everything she needed to know about how this interaction was about to go.

“Ah, Catra, I see you have deigned to grace us with your presence today, and so early too.” Sarcasm dripped from her voice and Catra sighed, knowing that she wasn’t a part of this conversation. “Well, what are you standing there for? You know where my office is.” The tall woman swept around, her long dress and academic robes swirling around her as she moved giving her every impression of being a wraith.

Trying to disappear into the collar of her slightly grey white shirt, Catra kept her eyes firmly fixed on the floor as she trailed behind the teacher. In the periphery of her vision she could see the edges of her burgundy robes and made sure to keep up with her. Though she could avoid making eye contact with the students

who were starting to crowd the corridors as, she couldn't not hear the sniggers and whispers as people saw her being taken to the office yet again.

Then, as they were about to turn the corner to the teachers only area, she heard it. Adora's gasp as she spotted her from all the way down the hallway and Glimmer's hushed whisper to forget about her and not be late. She had expected that Adora's friends would close ranks and tell her to put the cat-girl out of her mind. At least with Glimmer there she was saved the embarrassment of Adora coming to play knight in shining armour with the principle. It was barely 8am and already the day was ruined. She was left wishing that she had made her way back on to the roof of the mall instead of trying, and failing, to do the right thing.

Madam Weaver's footfalls became louder, clacking ominous as they moved away from the heavily populated area of the school and into the teachers inner sanctum. The corridors here were dimmer, the harsh fluorescent light that greeted the students replaced by warmer, more yellow bulbs. Ironic then that the place should feel so cold and foreboding. There was no sign of life here other than the wrathful woman and her favourite victim. No other teachers popped out of the staffroom or the study to greet the imposing woman, everybody already seated in their classrooms ready to start the day in front of a sea of overly keen faces.

Catra was so caught up in her own regret and self recrimination, that she almost barrelled into the back of the woman who had now stopped to unlock the heavy door of her office. Only her preternatural reflexes stopped her from further antagonising the woman.

Once the door was opened and a boney hand had reached over to flick on the light, throwing as many shadows around as light, Catra was silently beckoned to stand in front of the broad, highly polished oak desk while Madam Weaver seated herself around it. Catra's eyes darted around, already too familiar with this room for her own good, looking for anything out of place that could distract her from the inevitable dressing down she was about to receive.

There was nothing. Everything was as pristine and orderly as it every was, every paper and pen in its right place; monitor angled away from the guest and keyboard nestled beneath it until it was pulled out and those hands flew across it, waking the slumbering technology.

As the keys click-clacked, her eyes strayed to the window that dominated the wall to her left. The view out was of the quad, and meant that Weaver was always watching them. Today the weather outside mirrored how she felt. It was cold and dreary, a sluggish drizzle starting to paint streaks down the glass. Catra knew that it was just as cold out there as it looked, it was one of the deciding factors in her making her way in today. It was just too cold to spend the day outside, fur or no fur. The dark clouds blocking the sun meant that it felt strangely like twilight, as though she were experiences something out of the ordinary in this eerily quiet room.

She felt, more than saw, Madam Weaver shift in her seat, and turned her attention back to the woman who was now appraising her with those dark, hawklike eyes. Weaver's fingers were steepled in front of her and she let the silence strength for an uncomfortably long time. In other schools, Catra would have flopped into a chair without permission and sprawled out with a bored expression on her face. Not here though. She felt out of place in this school and under the microscopic gaze of this women who clearly loathed her, she tried not to attract any more of her ire.

"So, it seems that you have been cosying up with our star athlete." These were not the words that she had expected to come out of the woman's mouth. She was blindsided, having expected to be raked over the coals for any number of things from her truancy to her recalcitrance.

Weaver rose and stalked around the desk, prowling around the girl who held herself rigidly still, hands kept at her side and claws carefully away. Catra couldn't stop her hackles rising though, and was thankful that her shirt and blazer hid this. AS she moved,

Madam Weaver sighed and tutted under breath as she appraised this stain on her institution.

"Adora is not here to have her time and energy be taken up with the likes of you. She is a star in the making and that needs to be her entire focus. We can't have you distracting her." So, obviously it had got around the school that she and Adora had fallen out. Maybe it meant that the other girl had been moping around? Although she was worried, a little part of her was elated that Adora might be feeling sad about the loss of her.

"We aren't friends, Ma'am. She was just being nice to me after the accident." She saw Weaver's brows raise expectantly, clearly wanting to hear more. "We aren't hanging out any more." There it was, the self satisfied smirk that showed this was exactly what the woman wanted to hear.

"I knew somebody like you wouldn't be able to hold Adora's attention. She is, after all, a high flyer. She surrounds herself with people like her, who push her to be her best." She was crossing back to her seat now, visibly more relaxed.

Catra was hoping that was the end of this torture, and that she would be packed off, late, to her first class. Her ears quivered, waiting for the dismissal to come. And waited. And waited. The sound of their combined breathing, and the keys of the computer, filling the space between them. Catra felt her anxiety rise and rise until she was almost crawling out of her skin.

"As for your truancy," the words broke the silence like a thunder clap even though they were spoken lowly. "You are at this school only for as long as you follow our rules. Your scholarship becomes void as soon as you break these very simple terms." The word simple was purred.

Catra was certain that she was not expected to respond to these words, just stand and take it. "I have had several complaints from your teachers about your attitude and general demeanour in

lessons.” Catra could guess which teachers those complaints came from, “and you have not been attending school, have you?”

“No ma’am.” There was no point in denying it.

“It looks like we shall have to contact your parol officer.” It was clearly intended to goad her, but she couldn’t stop herself from reacting.

“Social worker.” She couldn’t help but growl it.

“Oh yes, silly me. Well, it’s only a matter of time though isn’t it?” The dark chuckle made Catra feel sick.

Silence stretched between them again and Catra realised that Madam Weaver had failed to make the connection between her social worker and Adora. It was understandable, Miss Hope and Adora did not share a last name and looked very different. She was thankful, at least it meant that the principle wouldn’t bad mouth her to the tall woman.

“Go.” She didn’t even look up from her monitor as she made a shooing gesture.

Catra didn’t hang around scrambling out of the room without any poise, and back down the hallway. She found herself at the crossroads between the exit and her classroom, and chose the path of least resistance.

# Chapter 3

Hope knew, even before she knocked on the door of the group home, that the girl she was looking for would not be inside. It wasn't the first time, nor would it be the last, that she'd received a call from the girl's school and found herself on a perverse game of hide and seek for her. She almost always caught up with her in a few hours though. But, as always, she began with that knock on the door.

The hybrid who opened the door was broad shouldered and blue skinned, his spiky head almost menacing but he had kind eyes and a soft, resigned expression as he saw who was at his door. They exchange the usual pleasantries and he showed up to the large room that Catra shared with several other girls.

As Cobalt push the door open, knocking first which pleased Hope, they were greeted only by an empty room. The three sets of bunkbeds that rested against three of the walls, two butted up against each other in an L-shape, were made tidily but not regimentally. There were throw pillows and old stuffed toys decorating some, while others had bags sat on top waiting for homework to be taken out.

It was easy to spot the young feline's bed. Catra liked to be up high. More than once Hope had found her sitting on the balconies of abandoned buildings, lounging across the thinnest of rickety guard rails in a way that gave the older woman heart palpitations. Her bunk showed no deliberate personalisation; only a single white pillow and duvet were folded on top. What made it stand out as the girl's was the absence of a ladder and the deep gouges in the wood that came from wickedly sharp claws.

"Have you noticed Catra acting differently lately?" She turned to the big man beside her as she spoke. It was a standard question, asked to tick a box, but it was taking on new meaning now. Since Adora had come home crying at the weekend, Hope had been

expecting an accompanying, but radically different, blow-up from Catra. It hadn't taken long to emerge.

"I'll be honest with you, Miss Hope, we don't see much of her even when she's in the house. Prefers her own company, that one." He folded his burley arms over his broad chest, almost looking embarrassed. "She does mostly join us for food and I'm sure she always sleeps here." The last few words were stammered out in a panicked rush.

"I understand that she isn't like your other charges, Mr Cobalt. You have managed to keep her here for a lot longer than any of her other recent placements, which I commend you for." She knew it sounded condescending but the man's face relaxed at her praise, feint as it was.

"Hey, didn't she sleep at your house a while back?" There was only honest curiosity in his voice but Hope knew she needed to give some disclosure.

"Yes, last month my daughter brought her home. The girls attend the same school, as it happens, and have become friends," she didn't say how close, for all she knew Catra would keep running from her daughter, their fledging romance already over.

"That's good to hear. Kids need friends, and other than that big scorpioni gal, Catra doesn't seem to have any." Cobalt seemed genuinely concerned, which gave Hope, hope. "I'm not really sure what to do about her truancy, damn kid…" He caught himself and blushed almost navy as he realised who he was talking to. He coughed awkwardly into his fist at Hope's raised eyebrow. "I mean, she's smarter than the rest of us, it's hard to use education as an incentive."

It was true, Catra knew exactly how smart she was. All that lazy, laid-back swagger masked the fact that she absorbed everything she heard. Not always a positive for her mental health, but it certainly served her well in class. It was nice to hear one of her care givers acknowledge what she know about the girl.

“Mr Cobalt, can I ask that you keep me posted about any time you aren’t sure that she slept here? It is a safety concern. Obviously the school will contact me about her absence. “

The pair made their way back downstairs just in time to watch a handful of the teen residents barrel through the doors. They were laughing and tussling like any group of siblings, smiling and waving at Cobalt as they saw him approach. Even Hope got small smiles from those that she had met before. This seems like one of the happier homes that she regularly visited.

At the door, Cobalt turned dark, serious eyes on her, “Do you need me to come and look for her with you? School said they hadn’t seen her all day. “

“No, I’m pretty sure I know where she’ll be. Sometimes she is a real creature of habit.” Another rush of kids swept through the doors, brushing passed the tall woman on their way to the family room. “Looks like you have your hands full anyway.”

She ducked out after that, quite literally having to slouch to avoid the doorframe, and headed to her car. She had already driven past a couple of Catra’s usual haunts on her way over but seen no sign of her. The next two places on her list were most likely. Reaching forward, she tapped the big screen on the dash and the droning sound of a phone trying to connect filled the cabin.

“Hello? “The distracted, questioning tone to Mara’s voice told Hope everything she needed to know. In the last few weeks before a tournament things grew frenetic in their home, Adora and Mara planning, practising and packing like whirlwinds.

“Hello love,” a sigh filled the car as Mara realised who was on the line, a sure sign that she had picked up without checking her caller ID.

“Hope, honey, you’ll never believe what happened today!” And she was off, rattling through information that Hope go maybe a third of. In a lot of ways, a Adora was every bit Mara’s daughter, and

this was one of them. Luckily, she knew the shorter woman would run through it all again later as they prepared for bed in a much slower and more absorbable way.

Finishing her call with her wife, almost certain that Mara had only half been listening to the fact that she would probably be late and that she would bring dinner, Hope began her hunt. Hope I tried the roof of the mall first, it had been ridiculously easy to walk into the staff only area. Perhaps it was a smart suit she wore or her self assured carriage, more likely it was the incompetence of the security guard she could see flirting with some young women in the corner. She made her way through the back entrance and ascended the metal staircase until she reached the unsecured door. She had known where to go, Adore found it very hard to keep anything from her parents and had all too readily told them about Catra's graffiti after the first time the girl had run from their home. Walking out onto the roof in the waning daylight she was stunned by the art before her; almost every wall was covered in vibrant patterns and detailed images. She hadn't even known that the cat-girl liked art, let alone that she was talented. For a moment Hope imagined what it would be like if Catra had been raised by a family that loved and supported her. The girl would be unstoppable.

Briefly she thought she may have located her, noticing a bag tucked underneath an inlet pipe for what must've been the air-conditioning of the building. She'd gone over to examine it but realised it was simply full of spray cans and a stained hoodie. Getting out of the mall was just as easy as getting in and she considered whether she should contact the management and let them know that this was very unsafe, however she knew that that would inversely affect the young cat girl and she didn't have the heart to stop her doing something she enjoyed so much. After all, she only seemed to get hurt when she was hit by cars is driven by young blonde women and not being on roofs.

Once back in her car there there was one place left to look. Hope had found Catra there several times before but it was always a last resort. The girl was very unhappy about spending any money,

Hope was sure she was squirrelling it away somewhere, kids like her often did. She pulled her car up in front of the dimly lit diner. It was one step away from a hovel and how the health department hadn't shut it down yet Hope would never know. She got out of the car, making sure to set the alarm, this was not the best part of town, and strode towards the door of the diner.

When Hope walked through the door a small bell jingled above it. The patrons who were dotted around the interior turned their head to see who had walked in, saw that she was no one they knew and turned back to their meals. The woman at the counter made eye contact with Hope, clearly recognising the statuesque woman who had just arrived. She jerked her head to indicate that the person she was looking for was seated in the corner and went back to filling up the sugar dispensers that she had been working on.

The girl sat slumped at a table, spinning a thin metal case, held closed with a thick rubber band, in her hands. Hope didn't need to have been in this job for years to know that it probably contained everything she'd been able to square away, it wasn't unusual for children like Catra to have a 'runaway fund'. She was just glad to have found her before she had run. Noisily pulling out the chair in front of her, already certain that the feline had heard her approach, she sat down and folded her hands in front of her on the sticky tabletop, just waiting.

"I know why you're here," huffed the teen.

"Adora said that you two had a falling out?" Hope spoke gently, as she would to a spooked animal, she know if she said the wrong thing Catra would be up and in the wind before she could get up from the table.

There was a snort so full of self-loathing from the girl, that Hope was almost shocked not to see her claws slide out of the tops of her fingers. She was shaking her shaggy chestnut head, ears pressed close to her skull. It wasn't body language that she was familiar with seeing from the girl. She was usually angry or self

righteous when Hope was called out to deal with issues involving her, this was dejection and sadness that she usually wouldn't let anyone see. The case had stopped moving in her hands and was not clutched tightly in one, the social worker was sure that if not for the fur there she would see a white knuckled grip.

"We didn't have an 'argument' and I bet you know that." Those laser sharp mismatched eyes finally looked up and locked with her's, challenging.

"Adora said that she asked if you would like to come to the tennis tournament and that you got angry and left and didn't show up at school for a few days." Dissembling would just make her close down.

"Asked me?" The growl that laced the words made Hope shiver, something primal programmed to fear that sound. "Look, I know I flipped out. I knew when it was happening, but she didn't ask. Adora told me I was going, like some sort of stray she picked up off the street. Like I'm some charity case that needs her pity to show me a good time…poor little Catra in her ratty clothes." The case was slammed into the table top with such force that it bent and chipped the table.

"Hey!" The server's voice yelled over, her attention and annoyance being caught by the interaction.

Hope held up a placating hand and the server thankfully stayed behind the counter but now had a glowing eye trained on them. She turned back to her charge and was rewarded with a sheepish look and the damaged container being thrust into her pocket, safely out of sight.

"Oh Catra, I love my daughter but sometimes she gets excited and doesn't always say what she means. She asked us if she could ask you to come and of course we said yes." Catra sat forward, clearly about to shout something else about charity and pity, but she stopped her by continuing to speak in her low,

melodic way. “We like you. You and Adora seem to work together well. We told her to ask you, she obviously got excited.”

“Fine. Whatever. I ruined it then, didn’t I? She’s not going to want to see me anymore after how I talked to her.” And there it was, Catra’s philosophy writ large in a dirty diner in a shady part of town. Once you mess up, you’re discarded. No apologies and no forgiveness.

“Catra, let me tell you a little secret. The Furst women, they’re pretty forgiving and really good at listening.” Slitted pupils grew large at her words, even as the guarded posture remained. “Why don’t you come over to the house and talk to Adora? If she doesn’t want to see you anymore, you haven’t lost anything more than you’ve lost now.” She wasn’t sure if a lose-lose scenario was the way to go, but she gave it a shot.

“You making dinner?” It wasn’t a yes, or a thank you, but it was recognition.

“Mara asked me to pick something up on the way home.” Hope started to stand and was gratified to see the girl mirror her, hands thrust deep into her hoodie pockets.

“Fuck Hope, not from this shit-hole?” Hope couldn’t help but laugh at the horror in the youthful voice and the indignant ‘oi’ from the counter as they passed by.

Technically it was against protocol to be letting one of her clients ride in her car with her, but technically staying her social worker while the teen dated her daughter was against the rules but she could no more abandon this girl like everyone else in her life had than she could sprout wings and fly home. She settled in her seat and saw Catra look around the interior of the car with wide eyes.

“I hate to ask this right now, but I got a call from Weaver saying that you had not stepped foot in school at all so far this week?” There was that growl again, louder than the engine coming to life.

“That’s a lie. I was there this morning, bitch threatened me not to hang out with Adora anymore.” Hope didn’t love this bad language, but what she hated even more was Madam Siobhan Weaver dictating her daughter’s relationships. Catra’s arms were folded against her chest as she glowered out of the windscreen.

“Adora said she saw you in the hall first thing, but I had to ask.” Carefully pulling out into traffic she caught the yellow and blue eyes of her travelling companion. “Believe me when I say, nobody decides who Adora can spend time with except Adora. Certainly not Madam Weaver.”

“But I shouldn’t call her a bitch, right?” There was the smallest hint of a grin with the words.

“Well, not to her face at least.” Tension thoroughly broken, the two laughed.

“So, what’re you getting for dinner?”

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Adora stared into the mirror in the changing room and took a deep breath, trying to keep her mind focused on her opponent. This was to be her first tournament on the adult circuit, playing with the big dogs as Glimmer had phrased it. She smiled at the girl looking back from the mirror as she thought about her best friend who she knew was sitting out in the stands waiting for her to emerge. She had never had friends in the stands before. Her moms were always there, supporting her in everything that she did, but years of moving around hadn’t let her build up the sort of friendships that she had found at Brightmoon. All she was worried about was whether her friend would be too loud and boisterous, although she was pretty sure that Angela and Micah would stop that happening. In fact, Glimmer had probably been to more tennis tournaments and grand slams than she had. It was easy to

forget how privileged and refined Glimmer's life was, when she was so rough around the edges.

Adora didn't dwell on the fact that the person she most wanted to be out there wasn't. She propped her foot up on the bench in the changing room and re-laced twice, finally happy with the fit. She pulled a sweat band onto her right wrist and adjusted her ponytail, looking at the clock on the wall and seeing that she was only twenty-five minutes away from walking out on court as an adult and facing a seeded competitor. Reaching into her bag she pulled out her phone and pushed a new number installed there. The video chat opened and started to drone as it tried to connect with the calls recipient. Adora chewed her lip as she worried that her call would be declined.

"Catra, it's Adora!" The loud voice of Scorpia suddenly boomed out through the empty changing room, her big beaming face filling the screen. "How you doing Adora, pretty exciting!"

"I feel good Scorpia, thanks. Gotta go warm up soon." She was trying to see round the white haired woman to catch a glimpse of the younger girl.

Suddenly the image on the screen was a blurred jumble as though it was flying through the air, it was dizzying but didn't last long before Catra's smirking face was filling the screen. Adora felt her own face bloom into a smile in return. Catra was obviously in a different room to her friend, it was a lot darker and far too quiet for Scorpia to be there.

"Hey Adora, how you doing?" There was concern in her voice as she ran her eyes over Adora's face, no doubt taking in the pinched look of her brow and the lip that she had gone back to biting.

"I am so nervous! What if I mess up? What if I lose every point!" Her voice was fast and growing higher pitched with every word.

"Then you will still have been to an international tennis tournament at 18. You'll still be a boss, dummy." It was a very

Catra pep-talk and it made the other girl, thousands of miles away, chuckle and begin to relax. "Anyway, I watched a few of this chick's matches and she ain't got nothin' on you!" The world's grumpiest cheerleader right there.

As much as Adora wished that Catra were out in the stands, she was touched that the other girl had been looking into her opponents and was obviously at Scorpia's so that she could watch the match live. When Hope had arrived home with Catra, arms laden with take-out a couple of weeks ago, Adora had been so shocked that she had just looked at the girl with her mouth open until Mara had leaned over and closed it for her like something out of a cartoon. She had blushed in embarrassment and Catra had cackled. It had been a first thawing of the ice that had settled between them. Adora had missed talking to the other girl every day that they hadn't seen each other, the five days had felt like an eternity. Sure, she knew it was ridiculous but it was how she felt.

She had been surprised when Catra had taken her hand and quietly, and far more gently than Adora would ever expect from her, led her out to the patio. Catra had explained in a quiet, obviously ashamed, voice why she had behaved the way she had and Adora had to stop herself from face palming. She hadn't realised that she hadn't asked and she said as much. She had explained her excitement and the two talked for a little while, while the older women set out the take out on the table.

That had been a few weeks ago, and things weren't quite back to how they had been between them, but they were definitely on the mend. Mara had mentioned that it might turn out to have been a good thing, that the pair had been moving a little quickly and at least now they had seen some of each others flaws. Mara was good at seeing the positive in things, Hope was more pragmatic, but both seemed to agree that Catra deciding to stay home while she went to play was probably for the best. There would be other tournaments to invite her to in the future.

"Hey, I know you have to go do your stretches and shit in a second," it was true, the five minutes that they had to talk had

quickly passed. “I know you’re going to kick ass, ok? I have snacks and energy drinks here and I’m going to watch every minute and then when you come back you can tell me all about it.”

“Thanks Catra.” A voice began to call to her from the hall and she knew Mara was waiting for her.

“Oh, and Adora, you should ask Glimmer what Catra said when you’re done.” With those enigmatic words Catra grinned her toothiest grin and hung up the phone.

Adora shook her head, smiling dopily, threw her phone back into her bag and hoisted it onto her shoulder before turning to the doorway.

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